

The Evolutionary Psychology of BDSM:

Insights from a factor-analytic study of 136 sexual kinks in 33,668 adults

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BDSM Background

- BDSM = bondage, discipline, dominance, submission, sadism, and masochism
- BDSM is a popular subculture—especially among LGBTQ+ individuals—with its own social norms, events, and educational resources.
- Sexual kinks offer insights into human sexuality, but remain under-studied from an evolutionary perspective.
- In a large sample we explored the factor structure of a wide variety of sexual interests, including many sexual kinks found within BDSM.



International Sample

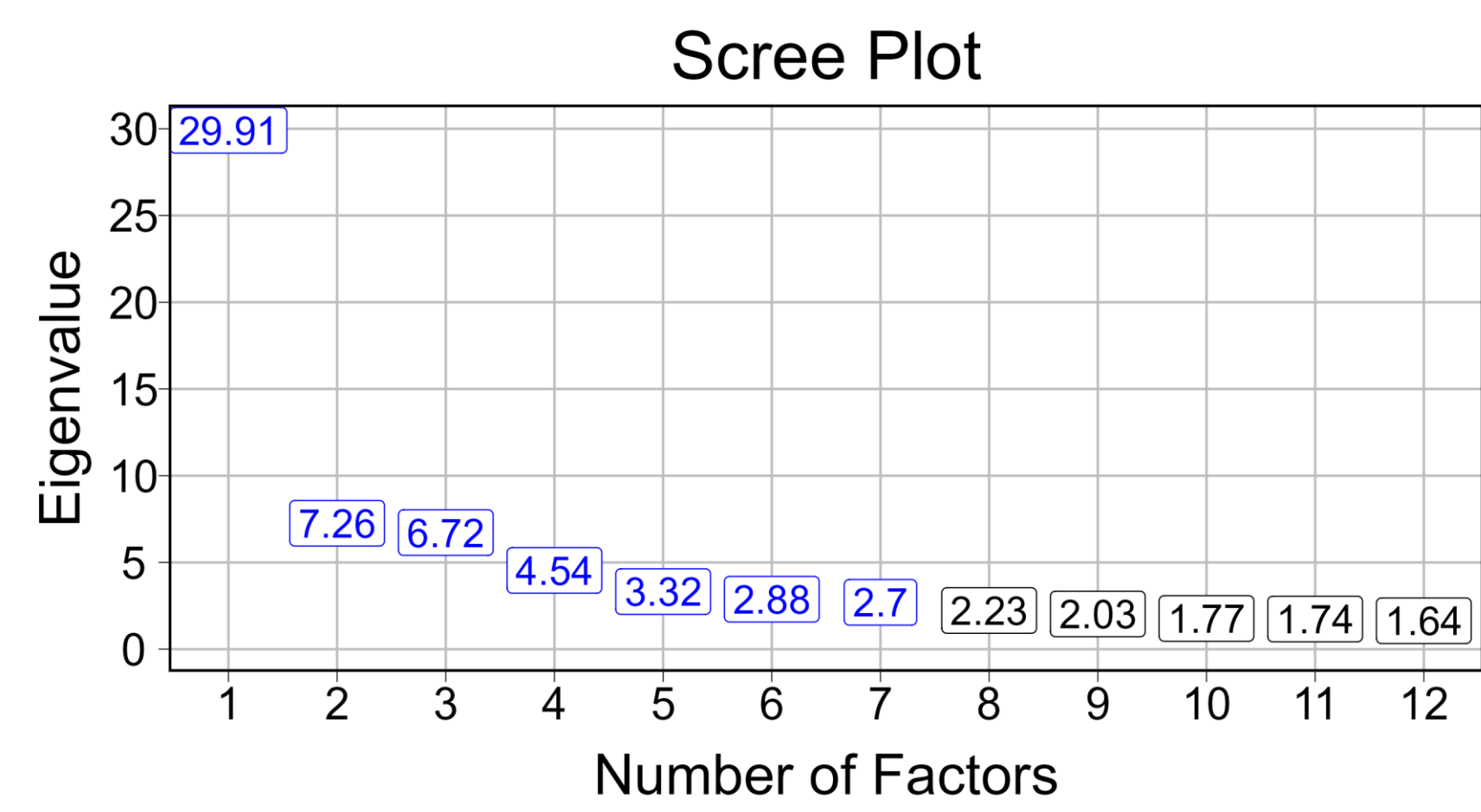
- The original sample contained 130,070 people globally who were recruited via social media. Participants were not paid for completing the survey. After exclusion criteria (taking the survey more than once, reporting not being honest in response, spending less than 5 minutes on the survey, younger than 18 or older than 80, and not being cis), that left 33,668 adults (21,671 men, Mage = 29.1, SDage = 10.6)

Online Survey Methods

- First, participants reported their age, sex/gender, where they got the survey from, and if it was their first time taking the survey.
- Second, before responding to how arousing they found each scenario, they read the directions: “this test assumes **ALL THINGS ARE BY DEFAULT, FANTASIES**. It is possible to ethically fantasize about a scenario that would **not** be ethical if done in real life. This test is about what would be hypothetically erotic, NOT about what you would act on.”
 - Example item: “I find sexual scenarios involving bondage to be:”
 - Response options were: 0 = not arousing, 1 = slightly arousing, 2 = somewhat arousing, 3 = moderately arousing, 4 = very arousing, 5 = extremely arousing.
- Last, participants reported how honest they were on a 4-point scale (not at all, a little, somewhat, very).

Factor Analysis

We ran an exploratory factor analysis (EFA) in R version 4.3.2 and its *psych* package (Version 2.3.9). The KMO statistic was excellent (.975) indicating that factor analysis was appropriate. Factors were extracted with principal axis factoring and an oblique rotation (Promax) was chosen. Seven factors were specified based upon inspection of the scree plot (below) and the interpretability of the seven-factor solution in comparison to other potential solutions. The seven-factor solution accounted for 39% of the variance. All factors (excluding ‘Scary Beasts’) were moderately/highly correlated with other factors (r ’s = .31 to .56).



Bondage & Discipline & Dominance & Submission & Sadism & Masochism.

Want to Collaborate?

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Kink Factors: Possible Ev Psych Relations and Sex Differences

Item Sex Differences
This background color represents Females scoring higher than Males
This background color represents Males scoring higher than Females
This background color represents no sex difference
<i>Note.</i> Numbers after each item are factor loadings from the pattern matrix.

Factor 1: Dom/sub power exchange	
- Dominance and submission dynamics in animals, mammals, primates, and humans - Mate choice for formidability, dominance, status, prestige, and influence - Female hypergamy (“marrying up”)	
Sexual scenarios involving sadomasochism	0.84
Dynamics centered around obedience, training, and punishment	0.81
Sexual scenarios involving bondage	0.79
Sexual scenarios involving power dynamics	0.78
Sexual scenarios involving heavy bondage	0.76

Note. A total of 25 items loaded onto this factor > .40; the top 5 highest loading items are presented here.

Factor 2: Attraction to feminine traits	
- Male mate choice for signals of youth, fertility, and nulliparity - Signals of submissiveness or exploitability	
Women/femininity	0.8
Skirts	0.71
Sexual scenarios involving two women interacting with each other	0.67
Hyper or seriously exaggerated femininity (e.g., long hair)	0.63
Large breasts	0.62

Note. A total of 18 items loaded onto this factor > .40; the top 5 highest loading items are presented here.

Factor 3: Sexual coercion and incest	
- Selection for sexual coercion, stalking, and abduction - Anthropological work on “marriage by capture” - Female attraction to Dark Triad traits	
Sexual scenarios involving nonconsent, boundary pushing, etc.	0.62
Sexual scenarios involving rapeplay	0.62
Sexual scenarios involving clear nonconsent	0.6
Scenarios involving incest between a brother and sister	0.59
Sexual scenarios involving dubious consent	0.58

Note. A total of 10 items loaded onto this factor > .40; the top 5 highest loading items are presented here.

Factor 4: Body disgust	
- Anti-pathogen disgust, sexual disgust, and moral disgust - Any other ideas??	
Sexual scenarios focused on scat/poop	0.74
Farts or belches	0.67
Dirtiness/disgust/messiness	0.64
Sexual scenarios focused on urine/urination	0.6
Sexual scenarios WAM/sploshing	0.59

Note. A total of 11 items loaded onto this factor > .40; the top 5 highest loading items are presented here.

Factor 5: Romance and sensuality	
- Pair bonding, romantic love, costly signals of commitment - Signaling self-control, conscientiousness, agreeableness - Relation to BDSM ‘aftercare’	
Gentle sensuality, like slowly kissing a partner all over their body	0.89
Romance/romantic scenarios	0.88
Long, passionate makeouts with a romantic partner	0.82
Sexual scenarios involving gentleness	0.79
Lips	0.59

Note. A total of 7 items loaded onto this factor > .40; the top 5 highest loading items are presented here.

Factor 6: Scary Beasts	
- Dominance/hypergamy superstimuli? - Power animals, shamanism, totemism?	
Sexual scenarios involving monsters (such as orcs, beasts, etc.)	0.71
Sexual scenarios involving mythical/fictional creatures	0.7
People or characters with tails and/or horns	0.69
Sexual scenarios involving animal transformations	0.59
Sexual scenarios involving gender transformations	0.51

Note. A total of 13 items loaded onto this factor > .40; the top 5 highest loading items are presented here.

Factor 7: Genderswap/Futanari	
- Autogynephilia? - Bisexuality? Androgyny? - Sex-combo superstimuli (futanari)	
Genderswapped body parts	0.79
Sexual scenarios involving genderplay	0.76
Futanari	0.74
Sexual scenarios involving gender transformations	0.69
Pegging	0.68

Note. A total of 7 items loaded onto this factor > .40; the top 5 highest loading items are presented here.

